

Through the eyes of a modern tactics player

"My reference points are XCOM, Into the Breach, Fire Emblem, Midnight Suns, Banner Saga. I want meaningful decisions with legible consequences."

6.5

OVERALL

Great meta-layer, thin battlefield

8.0

BUILD /
THEORYCRAFT
Deep and fun

3.0

POSITIONING
There is none

4.0

VARIANCE CONTROL
Luck decides too much

Let me set expectations honestly

When someone says "tactics," my brain loads a **grid**: cover, flanking, zones of control, line of sight, the agony of one tile. Isekai Strategem is not that. It's a *squad battler* — two lines of three trading turns, closer to Slay the Spire's combat or a party-based JRPG than to XCOM. That's a legitimate genre and it can be excellent. But measured against the tactics games I actually play, it's missing two of the pillars I come for, and it has one variance problem that undercuts the rest.

The meta-layer is genuinely strong

Where this game earns its "strategem" is **before** the battle and **between** the lines:

- **Loadout theorycraft.** 60 triggers + 9 Black Triggers + perks + a Trion-capacity budget is a real build sandbox. I can spend an hour optimizing a squad. That's my favorite kind of homework.
- **Team Efficiency Grade as a risk/reward dial.** A higher Grade gives dice advantages but *less* post-battle XP; a scrappy low Grade earns more. That inverse curve is a clever anti-snowball, straight out of the "rubber-band without cheating" playbook. I respect it a lot.
- **Queue + 6-phase resolution.** You commit a turn's actions and they resolve in a fixed phase order (buffs → control → attacks, with a Team-Spirit tiebreak). That's a planning puzzle most battlers lack — a little bit of Into the Breach's "order of operations matters."
- **Counters and combos** give me a reaction economy and setup → payoff lines to build around. Excellent.

KEEP

The pre-battle build sandbox + TEG risk/reward + queue resolution are your tactical identity. Don't lose them.

Pillar gap #1: no positioning means half the genre is absent

Every decision in a tactics game ultimately routes through *space*: where I stand determines what I threaten and what threatens me. Here, "melee" vs "ranged" are flavor tags — nobody moves, nobody closes a gap, nobody holds an angle. So the entire family of decisions I love — flank or hold, split or group, bait an

overextension — simply doesn't exist. You don't need a full XCOM grid, but you need a spatial axis (front/back rows, 3 lanes, or range bands) so that where an operator sits is a choice with consequences.

Pillar gap #2: initiative is a coin flip — in a lethal game

THE VARIANCE THAT HURTS MOST

Who acts first is decided by an **even 50/50 coin flip**. In a game where a single attack can delete a unit, first-turn is often the whole game — and it's pure luck. Modern tactics treats initiative as the *most* contested resource: Banner Saga's turn wheel, XCOM concealment/overwatch, Into the Breach's perfect turn order. Handing it to a coin toss is the least tactical decision the game makes.

You already compute a Team Efficiency Grade — that's a natural, earned lever to influence initiative (or at least to weight the flip). Randomness here should be something I can *build against*, not a raw 50/50.

Pillar gap #3: variance compounds instead of being mitigated

Great tactics games are careful about *where* they put randomness. Into the Breach removes to-hit RNG entirely and gives perfect information. XCOM keeps hit% but lets you stack overwatch, flanks, and abilities to control it. This game stacks its randomness:

Random layer	Effect	Mitigation available?
Coin-flip initiative	Who acts first (often decisive)	None
d20 to-hit (×2, opposed)	Whiff chance on planned lines	Advantage exists, but muted
Buildable crit (up to ~75%)	Doubles already-large hits	You can stack it — so can they
Random Trion income tier	Whether you can afford the plan	Loosely, via Affinity

None of these is fatal alone; together they mean a well-planned turn can lose to a coin flip + a lucky crit, and I can't fully insure against it. Tactics players will forgive hard fights; they won't forgive *feeling* that the dice, not the plan, decided it.

Information & AI

Good instincts here: enemy loadouts are hidden (fog of war) and `Mind's Eye` is a tool to *pierce* it — that's a real tactical information layer, and the public-vs-hidden intel gating on the new clickable portraits is a nice touch. What I can't see is the enemy's *queued* actions, so planning against the AI is guesswork rather than the readable telegraph Into the Breach spoiled me on. And single-player tactics lives or dies on AI quality — the roadmap lists AI tuning as future work, so I'll reserve judgment, but a squad-builder with an exploitable AI loses its tension fast.

Build diversity is being eaten by outliers

My theorycraft is only fun if many builds are viable. A few triggers are efficient enough to be auto-includes and collapse the meta: `whirlwind_slash` (cd 1, 12 Trion, 3-target, +bleed — the best damage-per-Trion in the game), `twin_fang_strike` (cd 1 single-target spam), and `longshot` (a ~104-damage one-shot). When

"just bring the efficient thing" wins, my build sandbox shrinks to one build. Tighten these to a damage-per-Trion-per-cooldown budget and the whole sandbox opens back up.

My tactics-player bottom line

1. **Own your genre.** Either add a spatial pillar (rows/lanes/range bands) to become a real tactics game, or market as a squad-builder battler and double down on the build+queue meta.
2. **Kill the coin-flip initiative.** Make first-turn an earned, buildable outcome (TEG-weighted or drafted).
3. **Consolidate randomness.** Fewer, more controllable random layers; give me tools to insure a plan (guaranteed-hit floor, bounded crit).
4. **Protect build diversity** by budgeting the outlier triggers.
5. **Telegraph more of the enemy's turn** so planning beats guessing.

Persona review 4 of 4 · Lens: modern tactics/strategy (XCOM, Into the Breach, Fire Emblem, Banner Saga, Midnight Suns). Grounded in the resolution model, initiative rule, TEG, and trigger economy.